

The stories we say ourselves

I'm fascinated, and a little confused, by how often people say one thing and unconsciously do the exact opposite. A woman says she wants a man who's loving, caring, a gentleman. The next day she's sleeping with a toxic guy who treats her like crap. The same pattern shows up in entrepreneurship. A founder says we're going to build a trillion dollar company, then enters a crowded market doing the same incremental improvements as everyone else. A VC says they want to invest in visionary outliers, then does consensus investing, chasing whatever round three other funds already committed to.

At some point I stopped trusting words at face value. Words are cheap and mostly performed. What actually tells you who someone is, is the underlying math, the unconscious behavior driving them, not the sentence they said out loud five minutes ago.

Every person is carrying a belief system, built up over years from what they've lived through, not from what they'd like to believe about themselves. That belief system generates a narrative, a story the person tells themselves about who they are and what they're doing here. And that narrative, not the words, is what drives behavior. The words someone says out loud are a separate, more socially acceptable story, optimized for how they want to be seen. The narrative running behavior is buried deeper, and it doesn't care how it sounds.

That's why the woman and the toxic guy isn't a contradiction, it's two narratives operating on two different layers. The spoken one says "I deserve someone loving." The operating one, built from whatever she's actually lived through, says something closer to "chaos feels like home" or "calm feels fake." The behavior always obeys the operating narrative, never the spoken one. Same with the founder. "Trillion dollar company" is the pitch deck narrative, built for investors and Twitter. The operating narrative, the one actually running their decisions, might be "I need to look ambitious

without ever risking public failure,” so every decision optimizes for safety dressed up as ambition. The VC chasing consensus deals isn't lying about wanting outliers, their spoken narrative genuinely believes it. Their operating narrative is “I can't be the only one wrong in the partner meeting,” and that one wins every time, because it's the one actually wired to their survival.

Every human being, at the core, is driven by a need to survive. The daily decisions people make all stem from that. But because everyone's nervous system and lived history is different, the operating narrative built on top of that survival drive is different for each person, and that's what decides the behavior, not the survival drive itself, and definitely not the words.

Which is what makes someone like Elon Musk genuinely rare. Most people's spoken and operating narratives are two different stories running in parallel. Musk is a case where they're the same story. When SpaceX's third launch failed miserably in the second stage, he was left with little cash for a fourth launch that could either fail or succeed. A normal person's operating narrative in that spot says something like “three failures deep, if this one fails too I've got nothing left, file for bankruptcy and preserve what's left.” Entirely rational, entirely congruent with survival. But Musk's operating narrative isn't “I run a rocket company,” it's “I'm the person who makes humans a multiplanetary species, starting with Mars,” and that narrative had been solidifying for years. For him, quitting doesn't just end a company, it kills the story his entire identity is built on. So his actual move was: figure out exactly what went wrong in launch three, put everything that's left into launch four, make it foolproof. Same as the pitch deck. Same as what he says out loud. That congruence, words matching the operating narrative under real pressure, is the exception, not the rule, which is exactly why it reads as remarkable instead of ordinary.

And this explains people who look nothing like Musk too. Someone who stays in a safe, predictable job for thirty years isn't short on ambition, their operating narrative says predictability equals survival, so staying still is the rational move. Someone who

quits that job to chase a startup isn't more courageous by nature, their operating narrative says a boring, safe life is a slow death, so for them the risk is what keeps them alive. Both are obeying the same survival drive. The only variable is which operating narrative that drive got wired to, and you will never find that out by asking them what they want. You find it by watching what they actually do when it costs them something.

What's common underneath all these operating narratives, the thing that pulls “build a trillion dollar company” down into incremental improvements, and “back contrarian visionary outliers” down into consensus investing, is one thing: fear of social judgment from your peers, partners, and family if the idea goes to zero. Not laziness, not lack of ambition. A person will quietly trade the version of themselves they said they wanted to be for the version that doesn't get laughed at in the group chat if it fails.

So why do a small number of founders and investors keep taking bets that look like madness from the outside? Same species, same nervous system, same exposure to judgment. The difference is that their internal narrative about who they are isn't borrowed from what their peers or family think of them, it's self-generated, and it's been reinforced for so long that it's load bearing. Their identity isn't resting on the outcome of this bet, it's resting on the story itself, “I am the person who does this,” and that story survives the bet failing. External judgment has nothing left to grab onto. That's not fearlessness. It's that the thing fear usually threatens, your standing with the people around you, was never the foundation their identity was built on in the first place.

Everyone is running from the same fear, and the ones who look fearless have just built an identity that fear can't reach. Don't listen to what anyone claims to believe, including yourself. Watch the behavior under pressure. That's the only place the real narrative ever shows itself.

Here's the catch though. The same mechanism that makes someone immune to peer judgment doesn't come with a filter. It can't tell the difference between a coward

mumbling “this won't work” out of fear, and an engineer mumbling “this won't work” because the physics genuinely doesn't work. To a narrative that's become load bearing, both sound identical, an attack on the story the identity is standing on. So once someone's operating narrative gets big enough, the feedback loop closes. Real constraints, cost limits, honest warnings, all of it gets filed under the same folder as “naysayers who lack the vision.”

You see this with something like Neom, Saudi Arabia's plan to build a 170 kilometer mirrored city standing straight up in the desert. Once a leader's identity is fused entirely to the idea of constructing that thing, they genuinely can't hear that cost overruns, supply chains, and basic engineering limits are real. Whoever raises the alarm doesn't get treated like an engineer doing their job, they get treated like a threat to the vision itself. So the narrative keeps demanding scale no matter what, and something that could've been a genuinely bold project turns into a hole you pour money and ego into forever.

Total alignment between what you say and what you do isn't automatically a good thing, then. It's the same tool either way, extraordinary achievement and catastrophic delusion both run on it. What decides which one you get isn't how strong the narrative is, it's whether the narrative is fighting a limiting belief or fighting reality itself.

That difference is what separates every great innovator from every founder who just burned a few billion dollars proving a point. In therapy, CBT is used on people carrying cognitive distortions and limiting beliefs. The therapist doesn't argue with their reality, they hand the person a more accurate, more empowering belief and let them live their way into it until the old belief stops running the show. That's exactly what the best innovators do, except the patient is an entire industry instead of one person. Every “that's just how it's done” is a limiting belief wearing the costume of a hard constraint. A great innovator looks at the foundational truth underneath it and realizes the constraint was never physics, it was a belief nobody had bothered to question. Then they force the industry into a new belief through the product, through

storytelling, through taking the risk nobody else would take, through hiring the handful of people who already suspected the old belief was fake and wanted to go prove it. That's CBT done on a dogma instead of a person. The ones who get it right are only ever attacking the limiting belief, never the hard physical truth. The moment you start attacking the truth itself, gravity, cost curves, supply chains, you've stopped being an innovator and started being Neom.

The fascination, the founder story, the outlier's immunity to judgment, and the innovator's fight against industry dogma are all the same mechanism, aimed at different targets. Pointed at a limiting belief, it looks like genius. Pointed at reality itself, it looks like a mirrored city rusting in the desert before it's even finished. The only way to tell which one you're looking at is to check what's actually being challenged, a story people made up and started mistaking for permanent, or the truth.